



LANGUAGE WE SPEAK: A scene from the play *Crab*

Gautam Raja, 32, currently residing in the United States. His play *Vaidehi* is being developed and performed by several theatre companies in New York as summer workshop productions. Back home, Chennai has seen the emergence of some talented playwrights such as Anupama Chandrashekar, 28, and Harsha Dandapani, 30, besides veteran journalist and recent entrant to playwrighting Gowri Ramnarayan, who is now rehearsing her latest play *Flame of the Forest*, an adaptation of the tale of king Mahendravarman's obsession with dancer Sivagami. With several songs rendered in classical Carnatic style, as well as a Bharatnatayam recital, the play is steeped in the Indian ethos, even as the characters spout dialogues in English.

English playwrights have not been too plentiful, with Mahesh Dattani being a notable exception. "Though I've always written in English, my plays are set in India and are about people like us, who read and speak in English," says Dattani. Other sporadic bursts have come from writers in English like Gurucharan Das, Manjula Padmanabhan and Poile Sengupta. Part of the problem is the general lack of interest in theatre itself, despite several important productions in the last two decades. "Why should any young



SWAR THOUNAOJAM, 26. She struck gold with *Turel*, her first play. Is now aiming for a stint at Royal Court Theatre.

person today write plays?" asks Girish Karnad, veteran playwright. "It's a thankless job. First, you might never see your play staged, second, you will never earn a livelihood from writing for the stage, and third, with the life that we lead in the metros today, who can blame people if they don't come to the theatre to watch plays? If a writer's choices are writing for stage, television or films, only a great obsession for the stage would make him or her choose the stage," he reasons.

But the new breed of writers seem to have thumbed their noses at merce-

nary motives. "I have never written plays for money, I've done it to share an idea or a thought," says Ramu Ramanathan, 37, whose *Mahadevbhai* and *Cotton 56, Polyester 84* (translated by Chetan Dattar) have been performed extensively and to critical acclaim. What's more, even Karnad has started writing in English, "because I don't consider it an alien language anymore. I find that I am comfortable writing in both English and Kannada."

Making more Indian language scripts accessible to an English-speaking audience today is not considered an elitist concept anymore but a necessary function to keep the current generation of theatre practitioners as well as audiences engaged with the medium. And, making this happen are institutions like the Sir Ratan Tata Trust which made a project grant to Ranga Shankara, a two-year-old theatre in Bangalore to organise a translators residency programme at Adishakti in Puducherry to adapt Indian language

plays in English. Participants, including playwrights and translators, were led by writer and veteran translator Arshia Sattar. "The idea is to move performance texts from Indian languages into English so that the theatre community can start performing each other's works again, as it did in the 1960s and '70s," says Sattar.

As for the hardliners who still complain about English being a foreign language and not suited to the Indian stage, Raja puts it best when he says: "It's not a foreign language for me, in fact, it's my only language. If I have to write, it can only be in English." ■